

CORE FORMULA

Cue -> small move -> pause -> observe -> follow or release. -> Is it more X, or more Y — or something else? -> Is it more timing or workload? -> Short version or the detailed one — or neither right now? -> Would email or a quick call be easier?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Offer two clear paths with a way out: "Is it more X, or more Y — or something else?"

BEST FOR

- When a question is too broad to answer easily
- When you want to reduce someone's cognitive load
- When choosing between two directions clarifies the next step
- When someone is stuck or overwhelmed by an open question
- Helping a quiet or tired person answer without effort
- Narrowing a vague problem into something workable

PHRASE BANK

Quick · Quick two-option openers

- "Is it more X, or more Y?"
- "Now problem or later problem?"
- "Short version or the long one?"
- "Big deal or small deal?"
- "Vent, or fix it?"
- "Talk it out, or leave it for now?"
- "Good news or complicated news?"
- "Text or call?"
- "Sooner or later?"
- "Yes, no, or maybe?"

Warm / low-pressure · Warm, gentle options

- "No rush — is it more the timing, or more the workload?"
- "Whatever's easier: quick summary, or the full story?"
- "Do you want me to just listen, or actually help think it through?"
- "Happy either way — dig into it now, or leave it for later?"
- "Is this a 'need advice' thing, or a 'need a minute' thing?"
- "Sounds like a lot. Is it one big thing, or lots of small ones?"
- "Would a chat help, or would some space be better?"

Work / meetings / email · Professional options

- "Is the blocker mainly clarity, or capacity?"
- "Do you want to decide today, or revisit tomorrow?"
- "Would email or a quick call be easier?"
- "Is this a scope question, or a timeline one?"
- "Should we ship the smaller version now, or hold for the full one?"
- "Is the concern the cost, or the risk — or something else?"
- "Are we aligned on the what, and just sorting the when?"

- "Is this a 'decide now' moment, or a 'gather more' one?"

Narrowing a vague answer · Direct, clarifying pairs

- "Is it more timing or workload?"
- "Short version or detailed version?"
- "Mainly clarity or capacity?"
- "Is that a yes, a no, or a 'not yet'?"
- "Do you want the decision from me, or just my read on it?"
- "Is the problem the plan, or the people?"
- "Is it done, or nearly done?"

Softening and the escape hatch · Release and de-escalate

- "We can stay with this, or move on — your call."
- "Ignore the options if neither fits."
- "Or something else entirely — I might be reading it wrong."
- "No pressure to pick either — I just wanted to make it easier to answer."
- "Would it help to name it, or would you rather leave it?"
- "Say 'neither' if I've missed it."
- "We don't have to stay with that."

Pressure / conflict · Clarity first, then options

- "Before we go further — is this a today problem, or a this-week problem?"
- "Do you want to solve it now, or cool off and come back to it?"
- "Is the sticking point the money, or the trust?"
- "Are we deciding this together, or do you need me to make the call?"
- "Is it something I did, or something else going on — or both?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Too broad, too fast: "Tell me everything."
Better: Is it more X, or more Y?
Best: Is it more X, or more Y — or something else? Then stop and watch the response.
- Weak: Tell me everything.
Better: Is it more timing or workload?
Best: Is it more timing or workload? — only if that framing fits.
- Weak: That's wrong.
Better: Short version or detailed version?
Best: I might be reading it wrong, but — short version, or the detailed one?

DECISION TREE

If They add detail after the options

Follow the thread they chose.

""Say more about that.""

If They pause thoughtfully

Wait — don't fill the silence.

If They look uncomfortable or cornered

Release the move and widen it back out.

""Or something else entirely — your call.""

If They ask for advice

Switch to Permission-based advice (TC027).

""Want my take, or just a sounding board?""

If Action is needed, not a question

Act directly instead of offering options.

If Neither option is genuinely acceptable

Drop the pair and ask openly.

""Forget those two — what would actually help?""

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

Use the smallest natural version and keep it light. — *""Big deal or small deal?""*

Professional discussion

Keep it concise and non-performative; tie it to the decision. — *""Do you want to decide today, or revisit tomorrow?""*

Conflict or objection

Pair it with validation or autonomy release so it doesn't feel like steering. — *""I can see this matters. Is it the timing, or the trust — or something else?""*

Digital message

One sentence, one pair of options, no stacking. — *""Would email or a quick call be easier?""*

High-stakes moment

Lead with direct clarity, then offer options only if it lowers pressure. — *""Here's where I've landed. Do you want the reasoning now, or after you've slept on it?""*

Quiet or overwhelmed person

Offer two gentle paths plus an easy exit so answering costs almost nothing. — *""No rush — is it more one big thing, or lots of small ones?""*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person needs an open field, not a narrowed one
- You are disguising your preferred answer as a choice
- Neither option is genuinely acceptable
- They are already giving clear, detailed answers
- The moment calls for direct action, not a question
- They seem tense, guarded or already cornered

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Notice three moments today where someone gives a broad, stuck or overwhelmed answer. Write down exactly what they said.

Day 2 — Draft the pairs

Write five lines where a two-option question might help, each ending with an escape hatch ("or something else").

Day 3 — Weak, better, best

Take two of your lines and write a weak, a better and a best version of each.

Day 4 — Cut it back

Reduce your best versions by about 30 percent until they sound like ordinary speech, not a technique.

Day 5 — Add the exit

For each line, write one recovery phrase you'd use if neither option fits.

Day 6 — Say them aloud

Read every line out loud once in a normal voice; cut any that sound clever, coaxing or scripted.

Day 7 — Use one live

In a real low-stakes conversation, use the smallest version once, pause, watch the response — then stop.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I preserve their autonomy — was there a genuine way out?
- Did I use one move rather than several?
- Did I watch the response instead of pushing on?

- Did I stop when the energy dropped?
- Were the two options both genuinely acceptable?
- Would a simpler, open response have been better?